



Soapstone

△ Soapstone "chop" (seal) from Korea

Far into prehistory, soapstone was used for carvings, ornaments, and utensils. Flint aside, it may be mankind's oldest lapidary material. Today, translucent, light green talc soapstone carvings are widely sold in China, lacquered to improve their hardness and colour, and to make them appear more like jade. The name soapstone is used to describe compact masses of various minerals that have a soapy or greasy feel, the most common of which is talc. A dense, high-purity talc called steatite is sought after for carving.

Specification

Chemical name Magnesium silicate hydrate | **Formula** $Mg_3Si_4O_{10}(OH)_2$ | **Colours** White, colourless, green, yellow to brown | **Structure** Triclinic or monoclinic | **Hardness** 2.2–2.8 | **SG** 2.8 | **RI** 1.54–1.59 | **Lustre** Pearly to greasy | **Streak** White | **Locations** USA, Canada, Germany, China



Uncut steatite | **Rough** | Steatite is a compact form of the mineral talc. The finest examples can be colourful and translucent, as in this piece of rough.



Talc specimen | **Rough** | This uncut soapstone from Roxbury, Connecticut, USA, includes areas of compact mineral suitable for carving.



Steatite cup | **Carved** | This steatite cup from the ancient city of Ur dates back to the 3rd millennium BCE; it is carved in relief with scorpions.



Tumbler | **Carved** | This ancient vessel was carved from one of the many forms of steatite used by the craftsmen in Ur in the 3rd millennium BCE.



Rhinoceros ornament | **Carved** | Soapstone is still a popular material for modern tribal art, such as this polished animal sculpture from Kenya, because it can be carved and incised easily with simple tools.

From ancient to modern

Steatite in history

In the ancient Middle East, steatite was made into bowls, pots, seals, reliquaries, and statues. It absorbs and distributes heat evenly, so it was a good material for cooking utensils and smoking pipes; ancient peoples also carved moulds out of steatite for metal casting. The mineral is still widely carved into bird and animal figures by the Inuit peoples of Canada and Alaska.

Inuit carving This steatite and ivory owl figurine was carved by Inuit craftsmen from Cape Dorset in northern Canada.

